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CHAPTER

8 Interviews and Surveys in Legislative Research

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Abstract

Interviews and surveys are widely used in social science research in general and in legislative studies in particular. As research methods, they help us understand the thoughts and intentions of parliamentarians, making them one of the most valuable sources of data for the study of political behavior. Interviews and surveys may be personally administered as in interviews or self-administered as in questionnaires. Despite their importance, however, the current practice of conducting interviews typically lacks quality control whereas surveys generate low response rates and tend to suffer from selection bias. This chapter focuses on the use of interviews and surveys in legislative research. It describes some of the most influential works based on interview research, as well as the greatest challenges involved in their use. It then explains how interviews with parliamentarians are conducted and concludes by offering relevant practical advice and presenting tools for addressing the challenges of interviews and surveys in future legislative research.

Keywords: [interviews](#), [surveys](#), [legislative studies](#), [research methods](#), [parliamentarians](#), [political behavior](#), [questionnaires](#), [response rates](#), [legislative research](#), [selection bias](#)

Subject: [Comparative Politics](#), [Political Methodology](#), [Politics](#)

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8.1 Introduction

INTERVIEWS and surveys are amongst the most popular research methods in the social sciences, and accordingly, they are a frequently used tool in legislative studies (Morris 2009). Our understanding of the motivations and the behaviour of parliamentarians would suffer greatly if we could not refer to studies such as Searing's (1994) interview-based analysis of the different parliamentary roles, or the data and subsequent

studies generated by established surveys such as the European Candidate Survey (e.g. Zittel and Gschwend 2008). Interviews and surveys—whether personally administered as in interviews or self-administered as in questionnaires—deliver the most direct measure of the thoughts and intentions of politicians, making them one of the most valuable sources of data for the study of political behaviour. Yet in spite of their importance, the current practice of conducting interviews is often characterized by a lack of quality control and surveys by low response rates. In view of this, it is important to develop tools that ensure that the standards of good interviewing are safeguarded and that the interview partner has a chance to react to the interview situation. As for low response rates and possible selection bias, international cooperation and the application of statistical tools are recommended.

In interviews, the researcher has the fascinating opportunity of getting an insight into the mindset, the ideas, and the subjective analysis of an event by an actor who has contributed to a political process (Richards 1996). Interviews thus provide qualitative in-depth accounts as well as allow for breadth and depth; however, their major drawback is that they do not allow for reporting the degree of uncertainty of the investigator (King, Keohane, and Verba 2001). Hence, interviews are particularly recommended as an exploratory strategy for the analysis of areas that have not been previously researched, as well as in the case of events that take place in secret meetings, such as party group sessions (Lilleker 2003).

p. 168 Self-administered surveys are usually conducted by mail or online, and can similarly be used to directly measure the attitudes, positions, and ideas of politicians. In contrast to interviews, they allow for a quantitative analysis of the data due to a larger number of cases, and thus for a reasonable estimate of the degree of uncertainty of the researcher's inferences (King, Keohane, et al. 2001, 31). However, one drawback is that the absence of the researcher and the randomly assigned respondents may lead to mismeasurement since the intention of a question cannot be personally explained or the possible misunderstanding of the question wording avoided.

Surveys and interviews have certain advantages over other indicators commonly used for establishing the views and preferences of members of parliament (MPs). In particular, the attitudes and ideas of parliamentarians are reported directly by the actors themselves; thus, the researcher does not have to rely on more indirect indicators such as votes, parliamentary questions, motions, or speeches. While data on roll-call votes (Carey 2009; Hix, Noury, and Roland 2006), parliamentary questions (Martin and Rozenberg 2012), motions (Bräuninger, Brunner, and Däubler 2009), and speeches (Proksch and Slapin 2010) may be easier to gather, they do not necessarily represent the actual preferences and attitudes of parliamentarians. Although all are expressions of parliamentary opinions and activities, they may not directly reflect the actual preferences since MPs may be influenced by disciplinary pressure from a party group leader, peer pressure from colleagues, certain characteristics of a legislative proposal, or their own strategic considerations (for an analysis of the influence of preferences and party pressure on roll-call votes, see Ansolabehere, Snyder, and Stewart 2001). Nonetheless, the advantages of interviews and surveys come at the price that the reliability and validity of data therewith generated is harder to ascertain, a topic which is covered at the end of this chapter.

Following a presentation of some of the most influential works based on interview research, a section on interviews discusses the greatest challenges involved in their use, followed by a general evaluation of employing interviews as a research tool. Since there is surprisingly little information available on conducting interviews with parliamentarians (for exceptions see Baker 2011; Puwar 1997), the subsequent section of this chapter lists relevant practical advice.¹ In a final section, tools are presented by which the challenges of interviews and surveys can be tackled in future legislative research.

8.2 Development of Survey and Interview-Based Studies in Legislative Research

p. 169 Interviews and surveys differ in the degree of structure and research goal. Surveys, whose research goal is very clear and predefined by theory, are much more structured than interviews, since the purpose of interview-based research is often far more explorative and inductive. This is clearly mirrored in legislative research: while early interview studies have laid the initial groundwork, surveys are now used to investigate the respective concepts on a more routine basis.

Examples of the kind of exploratory research conducted by means of interviews are the studies by Lewis Dexter (1969) and Richard Fenno (1973; 1978), both of which involved extensive interviewing of representatives in the US Congress with a view to analysing their interests, their activities in committees, and their work in the election districts. In his study on the constituency work of 18 legislators, Fenno (1978) slightly broadened his approach, using participant observation in addition to conducting interviews with parliamentarians and their staff. Taking a slightly different angle, but also using extensive exploratory interviews, Dexter (1969) investigated the degree of influence that citizens have on the decision-making of legislators. A crucial study concerning the incentives to participate in legislative activity was conducted by Richard Hall (1996), again in the US, using interviews with staffers instead of the parliamentarians themselves.

A prototypical example of the development of concepts in legislative research and the different use of surveys is the research on parliamentary roles, which has built on the exploratory studies conducted in the 1950s and 1960s. For example, in a central and early study of legislative norms, Eulau, Wahlke, and their colleagues (1959) explored the representational role types of “trustee”, “delegate”, and “politico” with the open question: “How would you describe the job of being a legislator—what are the most important things you should do here?,” which they posed to 474 US state legislators. A similarly open and exploratory approach was used by Searing (1994) in his study on the House of Commons, in which he identified more specific types of parliamentary roles based on 136 interviews. Through their studies, these researchers thus prepared the ground for more deductive quantitative work investigating the various roles and representational orientations of parliamentarians; in fact, this has become such a well-established research field, that questions regarding roles and representational orientations have become a standard item in parliamentary surveys. As such, survey questions are now the more common method by which to determine whether deputies are more constituency-focused (“delegates”) or whether they prefer to follow their own judgment on what is best for general welfare (“trustee”).²

p. 170 A related body of scholarship is the research on parliamentary norms: while Wahlke et al. (1962) used open questions to find out whether there are parliamentary rules, later research on the US by the likes of Thompson et al. (1996), Hebert and McLemore (1973), and Asher (1973), built on this earlier knowledge. Research on European parliaments, e.g. Loewenberg and Mans (1988), Crowe (1983), Bowler and Farrell (1999), or Skjaeveland (2001), has similarly done so, so that by now, the use of established closed questions covering parliamentary norms in the form of surveys has become standard practice (e.g. PARTIREP 2012; Weßels 2003).³ Indeed, an investigation of the issues published during the last 20 years by the most important academic journal in legislative research—*Legislative Studies Quarterly* (LSQ)—shows that, overall, surveys are currently used much more often than interviews. Of the 481 articles published in LSQ issued between 1992 and 2012, 95 (20 percent) used survey data and 36 (8 percent) used interviews; 16 articles (3 percent) combined surveys with interviews. Out of the 111 articles relying on surveys, 38 (34 percent) used surveys conducted with parliamentarians and parliamentary candidates; out of the 52 articles relying on interview data, 25 (48 percent) used interviews with parliamentarians and candidates. This clearly demonstrates that surveys in general and surveys with parliamentarians and candidates are used more often, perhaps because these data are more easily available and sometimes shared between researchers. Interviews, on the other hand, are slightly less common, which may be due to the higher costs involved.

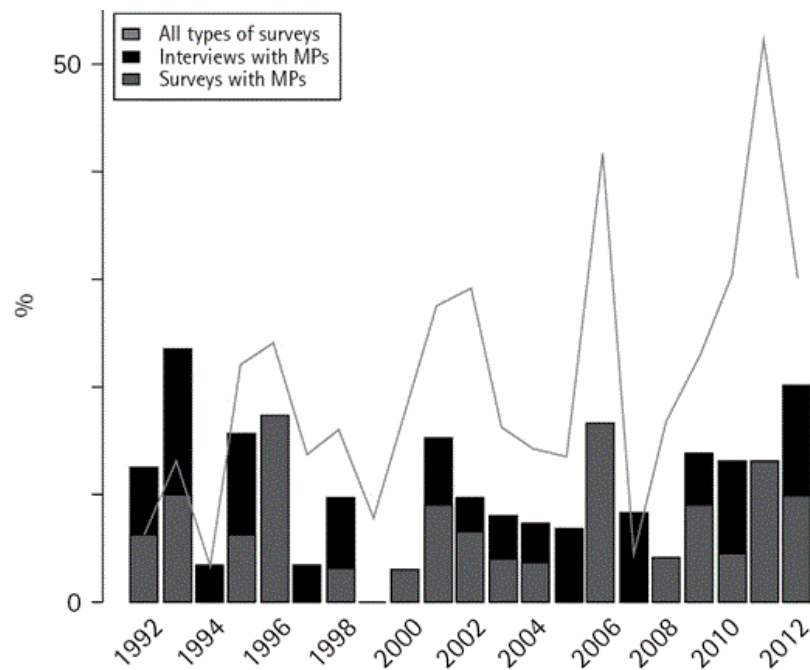


Fig. 8.1 The share of surveys and interviews conducted with MPs per year as part of studies published in *Legislative Studies Quarterly* (1992–2012)

Source: own calculations.

Fig. 8.1 depicts the general increase in the use of all types of surveys, including of the population, candidates, and parliamentarians (the line in light grey depicts the percentage of all surveys used in LSQ in the respective year). The black and grey bars show the share of MP surveys and MP interviews as a percentage of all the studies in *Legislative Studies Quarterly*. Here we can see that interviews are used less often, but that there is not a distinct negative trend, indicating that this method is still used for exploratory and in-depth research.

The next two sections discuss the major challenges of interviews and surveys in legislative research, as well as suggest practical advice on questionnaire design, question wording, and general interview rules.

8.3 Conducting Interviews with Parliamentarians

8.3.1 General Interaction Between Interviewer and Interviewee

Surveys and interviews with parliamentarians are usually treated under the heading of elite studies, where elites are defined as those having power (Lilleker 2003, 207), holding a privileged position in society, or being likely to have had more influence on political outcomes than members of the general public (Richards 1996). This distinction is often deemed relevant in that “interviewing up” (meaning studying elites, i.e. people close to power) has been found to have different implications than “interviewing down” (meaning interviews with persons not part of the elite, e.g. voters) (Desmond 2004, 262). To be more precise, interviewing up implies that “it is the interviewee who has the power” (Richards 1996, 201) in that he or she is in the position to control and dominate the interview by taking charge of the interview, changing questions, or refusing to answer. In such a situation, classical interview guides suggest trying to regain control of the interview and insisting on asking the prepared questions (Lilleker 2003, 211).

On the other hand, the distinction between interviewing up and down may also be considered a rather outdated approach that ignores the fact that all people who possess more knowledge about a special situation than the researcher—which is one of the reasons why he or she conducts the interview in the first place—are in a position of power. In this way, interviewers are inevitably in a weaker position since they are dependent on the collaboration of their counterpart. Despite this, politicians are, in fact, often found to show great respect for the interests of researchers and to be helpful and dedicated interview partners: “I have frequently been surprised by the level of self-reflection, uncertainty, and nervousness tangible in some of the most senior [...] interviewees as well as their willingness to share their thoughts with me” (Smith 2006, 647).

The question of power in interviews is further discussed in terms of the idea that interviewing up allows standards different from those employed when interviewing down. A powerful position on the part of the interviewee is often considered as legitimation for altered treatment such as the manipulation of questions, more subtle and more insistent questions, and a different level of ethical conduct, compared with that deemed appropriate for interviewing people with less power. This differential treatment is perhaps justifiable given that politicians are well used to the interview situation and are experienced in being questioned critically, to the extent that they are “trained” to look for questions whose answers might be used against them. Yet it remains controversial whether the superior hierarchical position of an interview partner indeed allows for a different treatment, since the power available to elites in their professional life may not necessarily manifest in an interview situation (Smith 2006, 646). Parliamentarians can also feel exposed and vulnerable in interviews, so that the power asymmetry is not only defined by structural power but also by the situation.

An interview situation should thus be considered as a form of social exchange, where the researcher and the informant establish a relationship based on reciprocity. In such a reciprocal or collaborative (Dexter 2006) interview situation, the interviewee has the power of access and information, and the researcher the power of dissemination. Such a collaborative approach allows for a fruitful exchange of views, where the mutual trust in a parliamentarian’s honesty and a researcher’s preparedness not to share the data without consent characterize the situation. Such symmetrical power relations are said to have direct implications on the type of knowledge that is created (Conti and O’Neil 2007).

8.3.2 Sampling, Contacting, and Accessing Interview Partners

In contrast to the challenges non-elite researchers face in identifying respondents (e.g. non-voters or protesters), legislative researchers are usually not confronted with this problem since the addresses of politicians are mostly public and contacting them is straightforward (Odendahl and Shaw 2001, 305). Furthermore, the sampling of parliamentarians is also rather clear-cut, since the whole population of parliamentarians in a certain parliament is usually targeted (Goldstein 2002). For more specific research questions, the sampling procedure can be more central, e.g. when all parliamentarians involved in a certain legislative project are to be investigated. In this case, a researcher can rely on *snowballing*, in which the interview partners are asked to recommend further interviewees to the researcher, a technique which can lead to high response rates but also to serious selection bias (for a description see Goldstein 2002). Another technique is the *reputational approach*, in which outside experts are asked to identify the key persons involved in a certain matter, e.g. a legislative reform (Hoffmann-Lange 1987, 30; for an overview of methods see also Maestas, Neeley, and Richardson Jr. 2003, 89). While this outside perspective might reduce selection bias, it can come at the cost of the experts not being as well informed as actual participants.

Actually getting an interview appointment can be “more art than science” (Goldstein 2002, 669), however, since receiving and scheduling interviews with elites is very time-consuming. Hence it is recommended that one allows for sufficient time and financial resources when conducting a research project using this method of inquiry (Odendahl and Shaw 2001, 308). An alternative is to take up an internship or fellowship in a legislature so that “embeddedness” provides easier access to the persons of interest (Baker 2011).

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To approach a parliamentarian, a written request by mail or email, using official university stationary, is recommended. Cultural specificities should be respected, e.g. whether email is acceptable or whether written letters are preferred (for an exemplary discussion of French specificities see Leuffen 2006). Overall, it is crucial to detail what the research project is about, and recommendable to explain why the addressed person is relevant and important for the project. “Buttering them up” (Lilleker 2003, 209) might help in such situations, by, for example, outlining how dependent this research is on his or her expertise. It is also useful to specify the expected duration of the interview, but since interviewing time can vary a great deal, one should indicate the minimum amount of time, and not more than 30 minutes (Harvey 2010, 200).

8.3.3 Behaviour During the Interview

Interviewees want to look good, they are skillful in changing questions, they can refuse to answer questions, and they may have memory gaps (Morris 2009, 211). The researcher is thus required to ask “good” questions as well as to undertake all possible precautions in order to minimize measurement effects and biases and ensure the attainment of valid results. In such a positivist approach, the interviewer is considered not to play a role when the data is generated (Roulston 2010). This, however, overlooks the possibility that the characteristics and attitudes of the interviewer can have a distorting for an overview of methods effect, in which case ignoring the role of the researcher may not be wholly appropriate. Somewhat reflective of this is the standpoint of the constructivist interview theories, where the interviewer and the interviewee are considered to create the data collectively, so that the data are “co-constructed” (Roulston 2010).

During the interview, researchers should make an informed (although not overly informed) impression, and present themselves as “friendly and curious” (Leech 2002, 665) in order to build rapport with the interview partner. It is recommendable to encourage the interviewee with little comments to demonstrate that you are paying attention, that you are listening carefully, and that “you are on their side” (Lilleker 2003, 210). However, one should not be too deferential and instead stay alert so that one can always bring back the interviewees if they drift too far off the subject. It is impossible to be a completely neutral interviewer, and it is perfectly legitimate to create a friendly atmosphere in which the interview partner feels appreciated, not judged, and encouraged, although direct approval and disapproval should be avoided.

Both the interview situation and the role an interviewer assumes can vary depending on the context of the interview, as well as on age, gender, and/or professional level of the interviewer and the interviewee (Puwar 1997). McDowell (1998, 2138), for example, describes how a quick assessment of a range of visual and verbal clues was sufficient for her to present herself in different situational roles, ranging from “playing dumb” with a patriarchal figure, being “brusquely efficient” with an older and fierce woman, “being sisterly” with women of similar age, and being “superfast, well-informed, and not to be patronized” with younger men.

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In any case, a researcher should always carefully consider the extent to which such dynamics might have influenced the interview. A couple of tools can be applied to diminish these effects: for example, an interviewer can ensure a similar interview setting by using a written questionnaire that includes short introductory texts that give a brief explanation of the topic before each set of questions. Allowing for greater comparability of the interview situations, such texts are also particularly useful if several interviewers participate in the data collection exercise.

8.3.4 The Questionnaire: Question Form and Order of Questions

Of necessity, the choice of interview questions depends on the researcher's objectives and on the degree of prior knowledge of an issue area. In general, a mix of closed and open questions is helpful for keeping the interviewee in line, allowing for comparability and guidance through the interview, and avoiding monotony. Including open questions is a must in any case, however, since this allows the researcher to more fully draw on the expertise of the interview partners.

In elite research, open questions (where few questions or prompts are given, and in the extreme case, only the topic with no specific questions is indicated, e.g. narrative interviews) used to be the norm since it was recommended not to put elites "in the straitjacket of closed-ended questions" (Aberbach and Rockman 2002, 674). Indeed, open questions are not only extremely valuable in that they give the researcher a chance to use the expertise of the interviewee to its full potential, but also allow for the possibility of discovering completely new phenomena and insights, and for a better flow (Lilleker 2003, 210). Furthermore, open questions permit the interviewees to use their own reference system in their answers. The great drawback is, however, that the responses are difficult to interpret and code: very detailed coding rules and a more time-intensive interpretation of answers are the tradeoff for probably more interesting and rich responses.

Asking open questions is also slightly more challenging in that interview partners might answer in new and unexpected ways so that it can be quite difficult to lead him or her back to the original purpose of the questions. Since guiding the interviewee through the interview in this way also increases the chance of interviewer effects, it may be useful to include pre-formulated prompts to help the interviewer in guiding a respondent back to the original questions. These can be slightly more provocative than the original questions and might thus help to receive answers.⁴ As already mentioned, pre-formulated prompts are also useful to reduce interviewer effects in situations where several interviewers cooperate in a single research project. Overall, they are thus a sensible compromise between open and closed questions.

Returning to closed questions during the course of an interview helps to ensure that at least certain questions are answered if an interview partner is particularly chatty or difficult to interview. It also makes the interviews more comparable and easier to code, and reduces interviewer effects. Furthermore, closed-ended questions enable the researcher to generate some quantitative data to complement the qualitative data obtained from the more open-ended questions (Harvey 2010, 203). They also give the researcher the possibility to signal certain normality when asking probing questions: for example, "How often have you been offered special benefits or payments for a certain legislative service?" can be a less threatening question than "Have you ever been bribed?" The drawback of closed questions is that unexpected answers are not captured, that the interviewee is forced into certain categories, and that they are often perceived as rather boring and might thus lead to a loss of attention and, in turn, to a deterioration of the quality of the data.

As regards the exact wording of open and closed questions, the reader is referred to Hermanowicz (2002), Schaeffer and Presser (2003), and Saris and Gallhofer (2007), which offer good initial advice regarding which kind of question-and-answer form is useful for which kind of research interest, e.g. whether middle categories are sensible in answer batteries, how many answer categories are useful, how to avoid acquiescence bias, how to use forced choice questions, whether to include "don't know" options, etc.⁵

When it comes to ordering the questions, the presentation of a general introductory text at the beginning of an interview is recommended to allow for a common definition of the interview situation, the research goal, and if necessary, any contested concepts.⁶ Following this it is generally useful to pose a warm-up question that is easy to answer for the expert, but which already signals that he or she is needed to answer the question. A typical example here is the “grand tour” question, which asks the parliamentarian or politician to describe “a typical day in his or her life” (Leech 2002). It is not recommendable to ask for easily available information, such as biographical details, at the beginning of an interview, since this wastes the time of the interviewee and signals that the interviewer has not done his or her homework (Hermanowicz 2002, 491). Moving through the interview, it is considered appropriate to progress from less probing to more probing questions (Morris 2009, 213). At the end, an interview partner should be thanked for their time and praised for their expertise without which the research would not be possible.

Special care needs to be paid to sensitive questions, especially because they are potentially the most interesting given that they disclose knowledge of experts which is otherwise not possible to obtain. It is legitimate to ask sensitive questions in a way that they convey a “normalcy” of certain behaviour (so-called “presuming questions,” Leech 2002, 666). An example of such a question would be: “A party group leader should ensure the unity of a party group where possible. Far-reaching means such as not granting a committee seat are legitimate to achieve this aim. Do you disagree/agree?” Experts disagree with regard to the positioning of sensitive questions: while some recommend asking them at the end of the interview, others find that placing them in the middle is the best option. This is because toward the middle of the interview, the interviewee has already been “warmed up” and can then be led to the more sensitive questions. Asking sensitive questions at the end, on the other hand, bears the risk that the most interesting questions may not get answered, given that interview times are often limited and that the interview may therefore have to be concluded early.

p. 176 As regards formatting, it is recommended that one arranges the questionnaire generously so that lots of page-turning motivates the interviewee to make progress. It is also advisable to have a second questionnaire at hand, in case interviewees wish to fill in their answers to closed questions themselves. Interviewers should know the wording and order of the interview questions well, in order to ensure a smooth flow of the interview and to avoid causing interruptions by having to look up the next question.

As to the recording of interviews, it generally is accepted that interviews are taped, although interviewees should always be asked if he or she agrees before a voice-recording tool is used. Taping has the huge advantage that the interviewer can focus much better on the interview, on giving prompts, and on guiding the interviewee through the questions, whereas noting down answers can take up a lot of valuable interview time and is prone to omissions (Lilleker 2003, 210). If the interviewee refuses taping, the researcher should allocate time directly after the interview to tape or note down as many impressions and notes as possible.

8.3.5 Judging the Quality of an Interview

A great interview, according to Hermanowicz (2002, 481), is one where the interviewer walks away with the realization that “someone’s essence or inner core—the stuff that makes them tick—has been tapped and bled to show several of the constitutional elements of the respondent,” while a good interview is one that captures basic and occasionally deep levels of meaning.

In practice, however, assessing the truthfulness of the interviewee’s responses is extremely challenging, especially since interviews are usually conducted when there is not a lot of prior knowledge on a certain topic. Here, interviewing more than one person about a certain incident or issue, cross-checking these accounts against each other, and conducting “implausibility checks” (Baker 2011, 108), are the only means of controlling for validity.

The interview situation itself can also be a source of error, particularly if the interviewee does not feel at ease (which is why it is preferable for interviews to be conducted in a location chosen by the interviewee, e.g. his or her own office), or if a certain situation is disturbing or distracting the respondent, e.g. after having lost a vote (Diekmann 1997, 382). Estimating the effect of these error sources on the quality of an interview can likewise be rather difficult, since the opportunities for elite interviews are so rare that two comparable interviews can hardly be carried out with the same interview partner. However, a careful transcription of the interview, including all prompts and questions by the interviewer, allows for more transparency and for detecting the ways in which the interviewer, the questionnaire, and the situation might have distorted the data.⁷

A new approach to assessing the quality of elite interviews would be to ask the interview partners themselves to quickly rate the questions, the interviewer, and the atmosphere during the interview on a short evaluation form at the end, in order to obtain an alternative impression of the interview to that of the interviewer. A good control question regarding the quality of an interview and the interviewer would also be to ask whether an interviewee would be prepared to be interviewed again in the future by this researcher or by someone else. If the person declines, the reasons for this could then be asked (e.g. lack of time, not an agreeable interview experience, etc.), which would similarly give an indication of the quality of the interview.

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8.4 Legislative Surveys

As mentioned, surveys have become an increasingly popular tool in legislative research. Parliamentary surveys are currently particularly widespread in Europe, as well as in countries where there is still less knowledge on legislative behaviour, while studies on the US Congress draw especially on the easily available NOMINATE scores based on roll-call vote data. This has, in turn, led to a decrease in the use of methods such as observation, elite interviewing, and “soak and poke approaches” in the US (Oppenheimer 2011). An overview of the most recent parliamentary surveys which make their data available is provided in Table 8.1.

Table 8.1 Overview of the most relevant parliamentary surveys in recent years

Table 1 survey name	country / parliament	year of conduction	general aim	method	available data	response rate	sample size	data availability condition
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Comparative MP Survey of PartiRep (interuniversity attraction pole participation & representation)	15 countries: AUT, BEL, FRA, DEU, HUN, IRL, ISR, ITA, NLD, NOR, POL, POR, ESP, CHE, GBR; data collection completed in BEL, DEU (state level), HUN, ISR, NOR	March 2009–January 2011	analysing changing patterns of participation and representation in modern democracies; cross-national survey among regional and national legislators in over 70 assemblies	variety of methods, depending on the partners; generally: contact via mail or e-mail, web-based survey, reminders and re-invitations via e-mail, backed up by letters or telephone calls; in a number of cases: face-to-face interviews	(1) The focus of representation: which are the groups in society for whom the MPs want to speak. Special attention is paid to territorial groups, especially in countries with a federal or federal-type territorial organization. (2) The style of representation: how do MPs perceive their task and which activities are at the core of the representational role? (3) Attitudes on representation and democracy: what is the meaning of democracy? Is there something wrong with representative democracy and how could it be repaired or improved?	national: 7.1% –46.7% (average = 24.9%); regional: 21.6% –40.4% (average = 31%) x
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European Parliament Research Group (EPRG)	European Parliament	April–November 2010 (latest edition, previous surveys were conducted in 2000 and 2006)	providing new source of data on Members of the European Parliament	contact via mail, web-based survey	personal details, electoral systems and candidate selection, campaigning aims and activities in 2009 elections, attitudes/behaviour to representation, committees and voting inside the parliament, general political attitudes, attitudes to EU policies and institutional reform	36%	270	access by contacting Simon Hix (< s.hix@lsu.ac.uk >); login necessary for academic purposes
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↳ Providing an Infrastructure for Research on Electoral Democracy in the European Union (PIREDEU)	European Parliament, all 27 member states	2008–11	providing an infrastructure for the (combined) research on citizenship, political participation and electoral democracy in the EU; improving upon the benchmark of the American National Election Study (ANES); origins in the European Election Studies (EES)	European Parliament Election Study, Candidate Study 2009: mail questionnaire, web-based survey	For attitudes toward political issues (position and valence issues), value orientations, perceived party's and voters' positions on issues, campaign style, strategies and means, attitudes towards European integration, preferences for distribution of authority between the national and the European level, focus of representation, attitudes towards party discipline, nomination procedures, information on political background and experience, migrant background, education, profession, religion, and standard of living	4.4%–42.9% (average = 20.71%)	free upon registration login necessary (GESIS)
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Comparative Candidate Study (CCS)	15 countries (conducted or currently being conducted): ALB, AUS, AUT, BEL, BGR, CAN, CZE, DNK, EST, FIN, FRA, DEU, GBR, GRC, HUN, ISL, IRL, ITA, LUX, NLD, NZL, NOR, POL, PRT, ROM, SVN, SWE, CHE	different for each country (maximum time span: 2005–11)	studying relationships between the candidate, the party and the voters	four alternative ways (plus combinations): mail survey, face-to-face interviews, telephone, on-line survey	campaigning, recruitment, career patterns, issues, ideology, democracy and representation	17.7%–66.7% (average = 40.81%)	sample size: 170–1871 (average = 700; total = 14392)	free upon registration login necessary
↳ Elites Parlamentarias de América Latina (PELA)	18 countries of Latin America: ARG, BRA, BOL, COL, CRI, CHL, ECU, GTM, SLV, HND, MEX, NIC, PAN, PRY, PER, DOM, URY, VEN	different for each country (maximum time span: 1993–2011)	providing data on the opinions, attitudes and perceptions of the members of parliament of all Latin American countries	appointment via phone, personal interview at the interviewees' offices	personal info (sex, age, education, salary, civil status, political career, party, motivation, political background of family, religiosity...); opinion on: divorce, abortion, democracy (e.g. stability, consolidation),	24%–90% (average = 57%) (Saiegh, 2009)	46–134 (average = 85.9)	free upon registration and signing commitment on confidentiality login necessary

elections and electoral systems, importance of political parties, left-right positioning of parties and politicians, relation between population and parties, level of democracy in own party, voting discipline, relations to own province and behaviour in case of conflict between interest of province and political party, independence of judicial system, free market or regulated economy, the state's responsibilities, direct or indirect taxation

↳ Asahi-Todai Elite Survey (ATES)	Japan, Lower and Upper House	2003 (members House of Representatives & candidates), 2004 (candidates &	surveying candidates and/or members (of House of Councilors and House of	mail questionnaires, responses returned by fax	personal information (name, electoral district, etc.); political circumstances (party and	76.7%–95.3% (average = 86.6%)	392 & 1104 (2003), 433 (2004), 1043 (2005), 433 (2007), 1301	free online
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		members House of Councilors), 2005 (candidates), 2007 (candidates & members House of Councilors), 2009 (candidates), 2010 (candidates and members House of Councilors)	Representatives) with regard to their policy positions on various issues		relations); major policies; personal qualifications; areas of qualified and strong expertise; personal opinion on coalition government; further policy questions: constitution, defense and security, foreign policy, social policy, size of government, economic and fiscal policy, privatization, agricultural policy, budgeting, welfare, education/culture, technological development, environmental conservation, international aid/assistance, internal safety, immigration, death penalty, regional policy, etc.		(2009), 457 (2010)	
↳ Project Vote Smart	USA	Congressional candidates: 1992–2012,	collecting and distributing information on	The methods are used varied from year to year. The	a candidate's most recently completed Political Courage	2012: 28.72% (Congressional candidates):	274 (2012 Congressional candidates)	completi registratio form (cont

State Legislative candidates: 1996–2012, Gubernatorial candidates: 1996–2012	candidates for public office, such as issue positions, voting records, campaign financing, etc.	standard contacts:	Test' & biographical information: personal information (marital status, education, professional and political experience, non- legislative committees, organizational membership), opinion on abortion, budget, spending, taxes, campaign finance, capital punishment, economy, environment and energy, foreign policy, guns, health care, immigration, same-sex marriage, social security; information on special interest groups and their ratings on candidates, state and federal key legislation and the candidate's respective vote, committees and	1992–2010: 38%–63% (average = 53.9%, Congressional candidates), 14%–38% (average = 29%, state legislative candidates), 34%–77% (average = 52.97%, Gubernatorial candidates)	intended usage) and submission payment required; f research purposes behalf of education institution US\$100
		1) Introductory Mailing (including a letter announcing the Political Courage Test, the questionnaire			
		2) Confirmation email (all candidates with email addresses in our database receive an email 1 week after mailing to confirm receipt)			
		3) Red Card Mailing (red post card sent to candidates 3 weeks before due date reminding them of the			

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↳ Candidate Emergence Study (CES)	USA (House election campaigns)	1998, 2000, 2002	understanding how potential candidates for the United States House of Representatives decide whether to run for Congress, examining intensity and content of House campaigns and how voters respond to campaigns	first contact via approach letter, mail questionnaires, reminder postcards	Potential Candidate Survey: party affiliation, personal information interest in holding elective office, opinion on redistricting, size of constituency, characteristics of current office, comparison of national, state and local level, future career, political philosophy (liberal-conservative), importance of factors for election, importance of political conditions for election, economic conditions), influencing factors of interest in running for US House	1998: 33%	informant: 1548, informant potential candidate: 2952, named potential candidate: 452, state legislators: 872	free online
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time spent on
duties, demands of
constituents
(personal
problems,
complaints to
central/local
government,
legislative activity,
etc.), important
factors for entering
first rows of party
electoral list,
important factors
for being reelected
in general election,
communication
media used by
constituents to
learn about a
politician's
activities

↳ Survey of members of the Turkish Parliament	Turkish Parliament	1995	gathering data on time allocation, demands of constituency and their solutions, motivations for party list nomination, election, media, constituency size, previous incumbency	mail questionnaire, phone reminder	Time spent on various duties of parliamentarian, demands of the constituents, importance of factors for entering the first rows of the party electoral list, importance of factors for being reelected in the general election, communication media used by constituents to learn about a politician's activities	19.8%	85	available f research u personal request to author: hazama@o.jp
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Surveys bear the great advantage that the samples of randomly selected respondents allow for the making of statements with regard to the whole population (Brady 2000); they also include a larger number of participants, and allow for drawing more wide-ranging inferences from the analyses and for estimating the degree of uncertainty. The following section outlines the most common and widespread surveys in parliamentary research and summarizes the general advantages and challenges of current survey research. In an additional section, expert surveys are discussed as a special form of generating data for legislative research.

Surveys are a tool designed to obtain information from respondents based on standardized questions, either via face-to-face interviews, mail, phone, internet, or a combination of these (e.g. visiting, leaving a questionnaire, possible follow-ups by phone). Nowadays, it is rather common to use online surveys, an example being the established European Parliament Research Group survey, for which members of the European Parliament are contacted by email and asked to fill in an online questionnaire (Scully, Hix, and Farrell 2012). With an online questionnaire, parliamentarians can choose a time suitable to them for answering the questions, and interviewer effects are non-existent. While online surveys are thus considered more reliable, they do demand internet literacy, which most parliamentarians in the developed world can, however, be expected to have (Johnston 2008).

Interviewing by phone or using computer-assisted telephone interviewing (CATI)⁸ has been reported to be rather successful even for elite and parliamentary studies (de Leeuw, Hox, and Snijkers 1995; Jahr 2006). Based on his practical experience, Baker (2011, 112), for example, recommends phone surveys for conducting interviews in the US Congress since he found them to be very time-efficient as well as flexible; however, he admits the loss of intimacy. Furthermore, while internet and mail questionnaires are considered to perform best in terms of the quality of answers and the distribution of responses, phone interviews are often criticized on the grounds of reliability (Johnston 2009). In comparison with direct surveying, phone interviews also bear the danger that “survey satisficing” behaviour is higher, meaning that respondents are more likely to acquiesce in question batteries and to differentiate their answers less (Holbrook, Green, and Krosnick 2003; Pasek and Krosnick 2010).

8.4.1 Response Rates and Selection Bias

One of the major challenges of interviews and surveys is the low response rate (unit non-response) (for surveys in general see Massey and Tourangeau 2013; for elite studies, see Montgomery, Cooper, Reiter, and Guan 2008; Gupta, Shaw, and Delery 2000), while the response rate is usually higher for interviews than for surveys (Maestas et al. 2003). The problem of unit non-response in surveys is that a researcher may be left with a very low number of cases, which could render the use of statistical methods problematic and lead to selection bias which, in turn, might lead to distorted results. Rates of non-response appear to be growing internationally as well as to affect elite studies as much as those carried out with regard to the general population, with the result that, by now, much greater efforts are necessary to achieve acceptable response rates (De Heer 1999). In particular, mail and online surveys suffer from low response rates since, due to the easiness with which online surveys can be set up, there has been a huge increase of survey demands so that parliamentarians are increasingly “overloaded” and thus less inclined to respond. The search for interview partners, on the other hand, tends to be more straightforward, yet non-response rates are often not as systematically reported as in the case of self-administered surveys. There are several ways of reacting to this. Firstly, one can try to increase the response rate by making repeated calls for participation and by conducting personal interviews instead of mail surveys. A very good discussion and demonstration of such a method can be found in Hoffmann-Lange (1987). Additional recommendations for increasing the response rate include the use of a respondent-friendly questionnaire, using personalized correspondence, and promising that results of the study will be made available to the interviewee (Maestas et al. 2003).

Secondly, low response rates as such are not necessarily a problem if they are not biased (Montgomery et al. 2008). Some knowledge exists as to which groups of parliamentarians usually do not respond as easily to surveys, e.g. parliamentarians from larger party groups (Weßels 2003) or politicians in higher offices. By comparing the means of possibly relevant variables such as age, gender, hierarchical level of office, party group, and career stage of the whole population (often the legislature) with the sample, it becomes obvious which “type” of parliamentarians might be underrepresented. A measure available for this purpose is the Duncan Similarity Index⁹ (Marsh and Weßels 1997). In the case that a sample is found to be biased, a possible remedy is the weighting of the sample, as for example in the state election study by Carey et al. (2002). Since they found that female members especially serving in upper chambers of states with short sessions and small population districts, and who originated from non-southern states, were more likely to respond, they assigned weights to correct for differential response rates.

Thirdly, by now several methods have been developed to model selection bias explicitly and to model why certain objects made it into the sample (Johnston 2008). With Heckman’s (1976) and related selection models, it is now possible to model which persons respond to a survey and which do not. Since we usually also have data such as party group membership, position, and age of those respondents who did not reply to a parliamentary study, this is a rather straightforward thing to do. Possible factors influencing the response rate are income, age, race, and working status (Groves and Couper 1998), however, we have much less established knowledge regarding the role of these variables in parliamentary studies (for an attempt to model survey non-response in population studies, see Brehm (1999)).

And finally, an alternative method for reducing the burden of filling out long questionnaires and thus hopefully increasing the response rate is a split questionnaire design, where respondents have to fill out only parts of a questionnaire and the remaining blanks are subsequently filled in by the researchers by means of imputing the missing data (for further discussion of these techniques, see Little and Rubin 1987; Raghunathan and Grizzle 1995). However, to date this has been applied mostly in population rather than elite surveys. In a similar line, there are statistical techniques for dealing with item non-response (when a respondent does not answer certain questions), amongst the most established being King et al.’s (2001) multiple imputation technique. This suggests an algorithm for filling in missing data as a possible alternative to listwise deletion and split questionnaire designs (Goldstein 2002).

Overall, however, legislative researchers still face the problem that their surveys receive fewer and fewer answers, this in spite of the advanced state of research on survey questions and current technologies that allow for conducting faster, cheaper, and more sophisticated surveys. In order to remedy this, a first step would thus be to systematically investigate the response rates of parliamentary surveys, in which specific factors, such as the length of questionnaires, the frequency and type of reminder contacts, the timing of the survey, and certain attributes of the respondents are used to explain the lack of responses. In the long run, it is also important to encourage, particularly on the part of funding agencies and journal editors, a better culture of data-sharing, so that parliamentary researchers can use the already conducted surveys more efficiently, and avoid repeating the same or similar surveys; an example of such an attempt is the webpage VoteWorld.¹⁰

8.4.2 Expert Surveys

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Expert surveys have become increasingly popular in party and parliamentary research, since they are rather easy to implement, comprehensive, and very flexible. By sending online or paper questionnaires to several country experts asking them to provide estimates on party positions, legislative powers, and resources, data on many aspects of party and legislative politics covering a large geographical scope can be collected. The expert survey carried out by Laver and Hunt (1992) is considered one of the first influential expert estimates in party and legislative affairs literature. This survey provided different party policy estimates with regard to 24 democracies and has since been repeated in its original (Benoit and Laver 2005) as well as in modified/revised forms by several scholars. In particular, the Chapel Hill survey stands out for its specific focus on the European integration dimension, as well as for the fact that it comprises a total of four survey rounds conducted between 1999 and 2010 and covers 24 countries and 237 parties (Bakker et al. 2012). An emphasis on legislative party groups rather than parties is evident in Benoit and McElroy's (2012) expert estimates of European parliament party groups (surveys conducted in 2004, 2007, and 2010).

A particularly useful and geographically more elaborate data source is provided by Fish and Kroenig (2009), who develop a parliamentary power(s) index based on a survey they conducted with social scientists, journalists, staff, and informed experts from 158 countries with regard to 32 factors that compose legislative power. The expertise of their interviewees is used, among other things, to distinguish between the formal instruments and the instruments actually used, so that an instrument was coded as a tool with which to exert power only when the experts considered it to be truly implementable. On the one hand, this clearly demonstrates the advantage of surveying experts, since they can distinguish between irrelevant and implemented legislative instruments. On the other hand, it also highlights a certain disadvantage, namely that expert survey measures are static and have to be repeated in order to capture any changes (Desposato 2012). Also, a further shortcoming of this data collection effort is the omission of a measure of disagreement or uncertainty regarding the experts' estimates, such as the standard error (Desposato 2012). In contrast, the Chapel Hill party positions survey(s) list(s) these disagreement measures, thus providing material for substantially interesting research questions such as that concerning the common practice among parties to deliberately blur their positions (Rovny 2012).

While there is an extensive debate on the use of expert data (as opposed to party manifesto data) for measuring party positions (Marks, Hooghe, Steenbergen, and Bakker 2007; Steenbergen and Marks 2007), the use of expert surveys for investigating the characteristics of parliaments is not yet intensely discussed. The advantage of expert surveys in general as well as in parliamentary research is that one can ask experts about basically anything in relation to which there are experts (Marks et al. 2007). Often, experts also possess far more information (e.g. about the actual use of roll-call votes in a parliament, as it was investigated by Hug 2012) than, for example, the document analysis of a parliamentary rule book would convey.

However, it must also be borne in mind that experts can only communicate subjective judgments, in view of which their answers are likely to be less reliable. Also, experts can often only be asked to give information about facts or situations which are not too far in the past, since—as in the case of parliamentary or population surveys—ex-post rationalization might otherwise distort the results. Furthermore, rather fluid or unstable objects of investigation—such as new parties—can cause estimation errors also on the part of experts (Marks et al. 2007). Finally, in the case of party position judgments, the surveying of experts was criticized by Budge (2001) in that it is unclear by what criteria and according to which time frame experts actually make their judgments. In an extensive evaluation of expert judgments of party positions, Steenbergen and Marks (2007) discuss these points of criticism and demonstrate how one can compare various measures of party positions using similarity indices. A final point of note is that expert surveys suffer from declining response rates, with some reporting response rates nearly as low as those attained in elite surveys. In an ideal world, researchers should use several sources of data to investigate their subjects. In the case of party positions, this is now easily possible since extensive research based on diverse methods (ranging from party manifesto analysis to parliamentarians' and populations' estimates to expert surveys and media analysis (for a discussion of these methods, see Helbling and Tresch (2010)) provides a rich database for comparing various estimates.

8.5 Conclusion

In spite of widely available data on legislative behaviour such as roll-call votes, there is still value in collecting data on MPs' attitudes, ideas, and insights directly from parliamentarians, their staff, and experts. The development of this field of research from the exploratory studies conducted in the early years of modern parliamentary research toward the use and formulation of more established models and theories of legislative behaviour has been accompanied by a shift in the use of interviews toward surveys. However, both methods are still valid in legislative research, depending on the research question and the level of prior knowledge. As the main challenge in applying these methods I have identified the current lack of quality control in qualitative interviews. In the tradition of the concept of the collaborative interview approach, a remedy against this could be a very brief evaluation form for the interviewee at the end of an interview which gives the respondent a chance to assess the interview situation as well as the interviewer. As for surveys, a recommendation for the improvement of parliamentary research is to lay greater emphasis on the coordination amongst the various researchers to reduce the number of surveys with which parliamentarians are dealing in order to increase return rates. One example of such a coordination effort is the comparative election research conducted via the European Social Survey, which is one of the most wide-ranging attempts to coordinate public opinion research (Curtice 2007). But even in this well-developed field of opinion and election research, cooperation is demanding, difficult, and dependent on institutional support as it is, for example, given by the European Union or the European Science Foundation. This already indicates that future attempts to coordinate parliamentary surveys, as in the case of PARTIREP, will be slow and dependent on individuals' efforts.

Notes

1. For a general introduction in qualitative interviewing see, for example, Dexter 2006; Kvale and Brinkmann 2009; Roulston 2010.
2. The wording of this question is usually similar to "How should, in your opinion, a member of parliament vote if his/her voters have one opinion and his/her party takes a different position?" (PARTIREP 2012) For a recent empirical comparative study of roles based on survey data, see Blomgren and Rozenberg (2012).
3. For example: "Would you say that the following items are true or false? Members frequently take parliamentary initiatives without the parliamentary party's authorization." (PARTIREP 2012)

4. An example of this is the question used in a project about the role of so-called “parachutists” (parliamentarians without party experience) in party groups (Bailer, Meissner, Ohmura, and Selb 2013): “What are the advantages of parachutists?”, with the following prompts: “Do they have more professional experience?”, “Do they have more expertise than their colleagues in certain policy areas?”.
5. A helpful introduction to the challenges of cross-national surveys brought about by the possible misinterpretations of question and answer forms can be found in Fu and Chu (2007).
6. Here, Patzelt (1996) cites the example of how the concepts of party loyalty, party pressure, party discipline, and party solidarity were first introduced to and judged for their adequacy by the parliamentarians, before their attitude towards them was inquired.
7. For an extensive example of transcribed interviews, see Dexter (1969).
8. In CATI, the interviewer follows a script provided by a software application and inserts the data while listening to the answers.
9. It is calculated by summing the absolute differences between the proportions of each of the two groups across each category of the scale item and dividing the total by two; it ranges from 0 (total agreement) to 100 (maximal difference).
10. <<http://www.voteworld.berkeley.edu>>.

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